“Do you want to tell me what’s going on?”

“I’m just having second thoughts, is all.” *Do it.*

“About me and you?”

“Yes.”

He ran a hand through his hair and, glimpsing the man she’d fallen in love with outside the cinema in Orléans, she couldn’t bear to look at him and turned away.

“Yesterday, we kissed and talked and held on to one another like we’d never let go.” He shook his head. “I thought we were solid. I—”

“There’s nothing wrong with slowing things down for a while.”

“You saved my life. I thought you and me—”

“Let’s be friends for a while. Then after the war—”

“Rose, I don’t want to be your friend.”

It was so hard. But her love for him was strong enough to lie if that would keep him safe and bring him home. That’s all that mattered. Not some idea of romance. Kissing in a cinema. She’d been infatuated. God, she sounded like Léa.

He came and stood alongside her. They were both looking out at the river. The water was calm and shallow. She could see the pebbles on the bottom, the way the sunlight hit them. It was what Léa had told her about Josef. At least Léa would have Josef. André would find someone. He was young, handsome and so loving. Reinhardt was right. She had to let him go.

“Are you saying you don’t love me anymore?” he asked.

“I’m saying I don’t know. And because I’m not sure, then it’s not fair to you that we keep on like this.”

“I can’t understand how this has happened.” He pulled her close. “Tell me what’s really going on.”

She stiffened, and he let her go.

“You mean it, don’t you?” His voice quavered.

“Yes, I do.” She held his gaze. She could see the force of her words settle like a weight on his shoulders and into the curve of his mouth.

He stepped back and looked away. “I see.”

“I don’t think we should meet in the afternoons anymore. I’ve got other things I need to do.”

He turned around, unbalanced, grabbing on to the stone column to hold himself upright. “Whatever you want.”